



Effective Presentations

Tip Sheet: Effective Presentations

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When presenting, it's important to be clear, to the point and yourself. Follow these tips to ensure your presentation is impactful and drives the desired action.

1. Tailor your message to the room

Know your audience and adjust your tone and the points you make accordingly. You may need to present the same idea or presentation to different audiences and your approach for each should be different and tailored to the needs of your audience.

Think of it this way: How will the group you are presenting to be best persuaded? If presenting to executive teams, that may mean a more formal tone where a more casual approach will work with peers or your direct reports. There may also be different parts of the presentation you want to emphasize depending on the audience. Again, the executive team may be more interested in outcomes or budget impact while your direct reports will likely care more about how their work will be impacted.

2. Timing is Everything

Presentations generally take longer to deliver than we anticipate for one simple reason. Once we get up in front of a room full of people, we tend to meander and add to our script. Sometimes out of nervousness, sometimes because we're just so passionate about the subject and sometimes because we make a false assumption that this is our one shot to say ALL of the things.

First, it is not your one shot to say everything. In fact, you'll have more impact by saying less – as long as what you say is on message and hits the key points you plan to make. Speak clearly and at a moderate pace: Don't rush through your points.

Below we'll talk about practice, but a big part of practice will be timing. You should allow some padding for moments to go off script, but also make sure you add enough time for Q&A with your audience at the end. I use a rough half-and-half rule of thumb: If you have 30 minutes scheduled for a presentation, use 15 for your formal presentation and leave the rest for Q&A. If there aren't enough questions to last the rest of the meeting, end it. No one will mind getting some time back in their day.

3. Don't read from the slides (most of the time)

Presentation decks should be visual aids. We can all probably remember meetings where someone just read their slides verbatim and wondered "Why couldn't I have just read this to myself on my own time?"

Presentations should usually be visual aids to bolster what you're saying, not compete with it. Meaning lean into images, graphics and short spurts of text that hammer home a point. If it happens that your presentation is more of what is called a mailed presentation* then the next step will be even more important for you to nail.

*(*A mailed presentation is more text heavy because it is being read by the recipient without the benefit of an oral presentation so is often more like a storybook – containing all the information your audience needs to understand the topic.)*

4. Key points for each slide

Go through your presentation (assuming you are using Google Slides, Canva or Powerpoint, etc.) and make a note of the main point you want to hit for each slide. It's not so much about making sure you hit that note as it is about making sure that one point is the thing your audience remembers from that slide. Which leads us to...

5. Practice OUT LOUD!

You'd be surprised how different your presentation feels and sounds when you actually say it out loud. It's important to run through a few times out loud to get a sense of your timing (how long does it really take? and how to introduce your key points. Even more importantly, you're likely to find a missing link or plot hole that just doesn't surface until you're presenting. Let that moment happen in practice, not in front of your audience.

6. Choreography

If there's more than one speaker, go through all of the above together. Make sure anyone who will be presenting is included in practice sessions and have a clear understanding of who is presenting which slide(s) and how/when to hand off between speakers.

7. Check your tech!

Whether presenting in person on an overhead display or on a Zoom call, make sure your tech is working. Ensure all equipment and materials (e.g., slides, clicker, audio) are working properly before the presentation begins.

8. Be yourself

Avoiding jargon is a good start, but to deliver an effective presentation just be yourself. Of course you need to know your audience and tailor your message, but avoiding jargon or corp speak is key here. No one really wants to hear a recitation of acronyms or corporate buzzwords. Your audience will appreciate the clarity and your realness and, bonus, you won't lose anyone who isn't as familiar with the topic as you are.

9. Interact and pay attention

- Ask questions or invite feedback at key moments to engage your audience and ensure they're following your argument. You can either do this in the body of the presentation or ask your audience to hold their feedback until the end.
- Pay attention to non-verbal cues from your audience. If they seem confused or disengaged, adjust your pace or clarify your points.
- Anticipate potential questions and practice your responses. Be ready to provide additional data or context as needed.

10. End with a Clear Call to Action

- End with a specific ask. Clearly state what action or decision you are requesting from your audience. Do you need a decision? Resources? Support? Ask.
- Provide a roadmap: Outline the next steps or action plan to implement your recommendation, including who will be responsible and any key timelines.